

Reviews

REPRESENTATIONS OF DEBATE IN FILM

Debate Team (2008). B. Douglas Robbins, Director and Editor. United States: Green Lamp Pictures.

The Great Debaters (2007). Todd Black, Kate Forte, Oprah Winfrey, and Joe Roth, Producers; Denzel Washington, Director. United States: The Weinstein Company.

Love and Debate (2009) (Thanks to Gravity, 2006). Jessica Kavana, Director. Virgil Films and Entertainment

Rocket Science (2007). Effie T. Brown and Sean Welch, Producers; Jeffrey Blitz, Director. United States: B&W Films.

Resolved (2008). Greg Whiteley, Producer and Director. United States: One Potato Productions.

Thumbsucker (2005). Anthony Bergman, and Bob Stephenson, Producers; Mike Mills, Director. United States: Sony Pictures Classic.

Debate trains students in the art of public speaking and advocacy, yet the activity itself remains largely insulated from society at large. Rarely do those not involved in the activity catch a glimpse of debate tournaments or the preparation that precedes them, resulting in perceptions markedly different from those of the debaters, coaches, and judges that constitute the debate community. A highly specialized and intensive activity that sometimes baffles those unfamiliar with its practices, debate nonetheless relies heavily upon outside support for their existence. It is

therefore worthwhile to consider the way non-debaters view the activity.

One avenue to social perception is to inspect the way debate is portrayed film. In recent years, numerous films have focused on debate or incorporated it as an important plot device. Analyzing the films in which debate appears to play a prominent role and the way debate is treated as a subject in these films provides an untapped opportunity for those inside the community to see themselves in ways shared by society at large. While not every film that we review presents itself as a faithful documentary, they all shed light on the cultural baggage debate carries as well as the social mystic of the activity.

The films reviewed tend to represent debate in either an overly positive or negative light, with little middle ground. This split did not correspond to the traditional division among documentaries and fictional films. Rather, the dividing line appears to have been whether debate was portrayed as a positive means of self-empowerment, such as in *The Great Debaters*, or as a symptom of alienation and isolation, as with *Debate Team*. Both of these tropes suggest that debate carries significant cultural baggage, and that it is understood by many as a symbol of individual transformation.

B. Douglas Robbins' *Debate Team* presents a rather negative view of the activity. The film documents the struggle of four teams – Michigan State HV, Harvard KT, Cal Berkeley NW, and West Georgia KT—as they compete to win the 2005 CEDA Nationals tournament, held that year at San Francisco State University. *Debate Team* alternates between footage of actual debates and reality-television-style confessions where individual debaters and coaches are interviewed about everything from their views of the activity itself to their own personal history. The documentary does not make an effort to empathize with its subjects. Rather, it revels in footage of debaters trash talking each other, making offensive jokes, and soullessly intoning their desire for

victory above all else. These images of the contemporary debate community are juxtaposed with scenes of former Houston debater Mike Miller, now a middle aged father, who gives the viewer the impression that life as he knew it ended when he was eliminated from the final round of the NDT in the 1960s. The resulting (and one suspects, intended) effect of these scenes is to paint debate as an inaccessible, hopelessly competitive, and often mean-spirited activity whose educational value consists largely of finding creative scenarios for human extinction.

This aside, *Debate Team* is not a dishonest documentary. Debaters and former debaters anchor all the dialogue, and the film's extensive deployment of in-round footage provides an "inside view" of collegiate debate. Although Robbins and crew may not like everything they find at the 2005 CEDA Nationals, they at least seem to give it a chance, and take the time to explain the format, structure, and content of an activity that may seem hopelessly incomprehensible for many. For those on the outside, *Debate Team* is unlikely to convert them to the cause, but it nonetheless gives them a good feel for debate tournaments. For those in the community, the film's value lie largely in its ability to force them to confront their own reasons for participating in debate, and provide a cautionary tale of warning for those who view forensics solely as a series of wins and losses.

In *Rocket Science*, debate similarly appears as a force for mindless competition, but serves largely as a backdrop for the film's more or less typical tale of adolescent angst. The film's protagonist, Hal Hefner (Reece Thompson), is an awkward, shy fifteen year old with a serious stutter who is inexplicably recruited for his high school debate team by Ginny Ryerson (Anna Kendrick) who happens to be Hal's crush as well as the school's star debater. Ginny has been left partner-less after her former teammate, Ben Wekselbaum (Nicholas D'Agosto) suffers an emotional collapse while debating, of all topics, agricultural

subsidies. What Wekselbaum perceives as the innate futility of switch sides debate (and, one suspects, Ginny's intolerable attitude) drives him away from the activity and sets the stage for the film's plot, revolving around Ginny and Hal's unlikely and unsustainable partnership. Hal's stutter makes him a poor candidate for policy debate, and his attempts to overcome it provide some comic relief, albeit of the "painful to watch" variety. The plot thickens when Ginny fails to materialize for her and Hal's first tournament together, and Hal's coach reveals that their partnership was little more than a part of a shrewd scheme to allow Ginny's school transfer. Infuriated, Hal tracks down washed out star Wekselbaum, and the two make a hilarious last-ditch effort to win the fictional Policy Debate Championship tournament.

Rumor has it that director Jeffrey Blitz was himself a disillusioned former debater, and it shows. The debaters don't orate, they spread. When Hal approaches Wekselbaum, the experienced debater assures him that if they just write one counterplan and get good at it they'll do fine on the negative. Ginny's plot to transfer schools to enhance her debate success, while seemingly ridiculous, did remind this viewer of similar situations in the debate community. Moreover, Blitz gets the atmospherics of New England regional debate just right; as debaters who learned to argue on that circuit, we found it almost eerie how accurate the scenes of New Jersey debate tournaments looked and felt. It was largely these atmospherics that captures attention, and, unless you consider awkward, independent, not-quite-love story films the pinnacle of film making, *Rocket Science* is nothing to write home about. The characters do provide a good cross-section of high school debaters, though, albeit a somewhat negative one. There's the hopelessly dedicated competitor (Ginny), the washed up star (Ben), and the one who doesn't quite belong (Hal). One might hope for a broader portrayal of high school debate and those who participate in it.

2005's *Thumbsucker* provides a similar view of high school debate, and here, too, the activity is more of a character device than an integral part of the film. Like *Rocket Science*, *Thumbsucker* focuses on awkward teen Justin (you can guess what his impediment is), played by Lou Pucci, who sees debate as a way to prove himself and possibly win the interest of advocate and environmentalist Rebecca (Kelli Garner). Like his counterpart in *Rocket Science*, Justin doesn't find much value in debate itself, but sees it as a means to an end, namely Rebecca and social recognition. Vince Vaughn plays Justin's coach Mr. Geary, an intensely competitive man who has little time for Justin until the teen starts taking Ritalin and becomes a stellar debater. Justin's newfound debate talents quickly earn him competitive success and confidence, but these go to his head, and soon even his family cannot stand his confrontational, know-it-all attitude. Even Mr. Geary, a coach so dedicated that he calls all of his female students into the men's bathroom before a debate to do speaking drills, finds Justin's competitive drive extreme. The two have an exchange after a tournament that succinctly illustrates Justin's view of the activity, and causes Mr. Geary to rethink everything he knows about competition:

Mr. Geary: Why do you feel good?

Justin: I'm winning.

Mr. Geary: What about learning?

Justin: I'm learning how to win.

Like *Rocket Science*, *Thumbsucker* is not a terribly interesting film on its own terms. Appearances by Keanu Reeves and Vincent D'Onofrio do little to speed up a not very engaging story, and the typical teen romance plot ends predictably in betrayal, embarrassment, and heartbreak. For whatever reason, both *Thumbsucker* director Mike Mills and *Rocket Science*'s Jeffery Blitz tend to portray women, and especially women in debate, as cold, self-absorbed, and downright mean-spirited. After watching both films, one comes away with the impression that Kelli Garner's Rebecca

and Anna Kendrick's Ginny could have switched roles without anyone noticing. It's one thing to stereotype an activity; it's another to homogenize everyone in that activity into either a self-conscious, bumbling boy or an attractive but manipulative girl. The resulting formula plays out better in *Rocket Science* than *Thumbsucker*, which falls back on these typecast roles in a more fundamental way than Blitz's film. Ultimately, Blitz's caricatures reminded these reviews of real people they know, whereas Mills' just seemed like, well, caricatures.

In *The Great Debaters* forensics appears in a more positive light. The film revolves around a debate team from the all-black Wiley College, and chronicles their historical journey to the national championship in 1939. Whereas in the other films debate is associated with competition for competition's sake, in *The Great Debaters* there is something far greater at stake. Set in rural Texas during the Great Depression, the debaters from Wiley College face challenges above and beyond just finding the right evidence or writing briefs. For them, debate is a way to combat racial inequity, a means to prove to the intolerant and prejudiced around them what they, and we, already know: that they are every bit as intelligent, articulate, and learned as the white students they eventually defeat. Denzel Washington delivers an excellent performance in the role of Wiley's historic coach, Melvin Tolson, a professor whose tutelage extends beyond the classroom and into the everyday lives of his students.

The film does is not centered around Washington, however. His students—Henry Lowe, James Hamilton Jr. and Samantha Boone—progress from timid students to talented rhetoricians and it is this journey that forms the backbone of *The Great Debaters*. As they argue about civil disobedience and segregation in higher education they gain the confidence and knowledge to productively confront the inequities of the period, whether racial or socioeconomic. Indeed, the film's class consciousness is one of its strongest points; it eschews

typical racial dichotomies in favor of a much more nuanced view of the time period. Ultimately, though, the film is about debate, and the power of argumentation and advocacy to spark social change. It's a utopian vision, but a wonderful one, and you can't be blamed for being enchanted by the persuasiveness and conviction of *The Great Debaters*.

Similarly, Greg Whiteley's *Resolved* explores the positive aspects of debate through an unusually motivating success story about two very different high school debater teams. The movie follows two pairs of debate partners over a span of two years, documenting for viewers the struggles and joys of high school debate. Richard Funches and Louis Blackwell, underprivileged students from Long Beach Jordan, California, fight to succeed, while a second pair of debaters, Matt Andrews and Sam Iola, from Highland Park, Texas, naturally enact their school's competitive success.

Andrews is portrayed as a rising star in Highland Park debate and is paired with Sam Iola, who has already proven himself as one of the elite debaters. Sam acts as a mentor for Andrews, teaching him how to debate and how to live life. After a successful run at the California Invitational, Sam and Matt get prepared for the most important tournament of the year, the Tournament of Champions. Matt finds a lot of meaning in debating with Sam, who is entering the last tournament of his high school career. Sam and Matt end their run by losing to Chattahoochee's John Warden and Garrett Abelkop in the semi-final round. Matt then follows up his brilliant sophomore career with a championship at the Tournament of Champions in 2006 for the Greenhill School, Texas.

In contrast to Highland Park, debate is not simply about the competitive success for Funches and Blackwell. Going into their senior year, the two African American debaters choose to debate about the inequities in debate. This strategy of "debating about debate" catches their opponents off guard and forces both their opponents and judges to reexamine the way they view debate. For Blackwell, debate

helps keep him in line and provides him hope for a college scholarship. The struggles and triumphs of Funches and Blackwell culminate with their run at the California Invitational at Berkeley. In need of a 6-2 record in order to clear to elimination rounds and thereby secure their bid to the Tournament of Champions, Long Beach Jordan FB falls short when they are eliminated in the seventh round. Despite the disappointment of their high school careers, both debaters find their way into college at California State University Fullerton and the University of Louisville.

Resolved sheds a positive light upon debate. If the viewer did not know that prominent figures such as Samuel Alito and Karl Rove thought highly of debate and the way it heavily influenced their lives, the multitude of interviews throughout the movie will drive that reality home. *Resolved* is a feel good story not just because it shows the success of under privileged debaters; but it is real and not a Hollywood drama. Debate is shown as a life changing activity that positively influences the lives of those involved. Moreover, *Resolved* tell not just the story of four debaters, but teaches the viewers about the activity itself. By including informative snippets, such as the origin of the concept “spreading” (speed reading), Whiteley’s *Resolved* creates a clearer picture of what debate actually looks like and where it came from.

Jessica Kavina's *Love and Debate* tells the story of Jordan Landa, a bright and ambitious young girl who finds a passion for debate while she learns to balance it with all her life complications. Jordan picks up debate in her last years of high school as an extracurricular activity. To her surprise, Jordan emerges to instance success in the high school debate circuit - competing at the Florida State Tournament in her first year. At this tournament, she runs in to the coach of Harvard debate, Austin, who is impressed by Jordan's debate talent and invites her to debate for Harvard University. Jordan's life is complicated by sexual assault by a fellow debater and a spiraling love life that causes conflict with her

family. The movie highlights debate as an outlet for educational pursuit and creativity that competes with Jordan's college life. The twists and turns of life force Jordan to abandon debate until she is pulled back in competitive debate in her senior year. The climax of the movie finds Jordan in the finals of the "National Debate Tournament" against the man that sexually assaulted her at the beginning of her debate career. After struggling to debate against the presumed favorite from Michigan University, Jordan is struck by a debate epiphany reminiscent of *Listen to Me* that turns the debate back in her favor. *Love and Debate* provides a general background of debate for anyone that is new to the subject. Jordan's high school coach characterizes debate in a viewer-friendly manner saying, "Everything ends in nuclear war!" and "Remember S.H.I.T.S - Solvency. Harms. Inherency. Topicality. and Significance." *Love and Debate* provides the feel of an everyday drama while providing an insight of the debater culture.

The films reviewed here reveal remarkable differences, as well as some fundamental similarities, in cultural representations of debate. Divergences in the films centered largely upon whether or not debate-induced social transformations had positive or negative effects on their subjects. This split extended across both documentaries and studio productions; debate appears alienating both to its real world participants in *Debate Team* and their fictional counterparts in *Rocket Science* and *Thumbsucker*. Lines of contiguity appeared between both types of films, however, and all seemed predicated on the image of the debater as the esoteric, bright social outcast. Indeed, while directors Robbins, Blitz, and Mills seem skeptical of the debate enterprise, they never for a moment suggest that those who participate in the activity are anything less than extraordinarily driven and intelligent. Their representation of debate as something of a cult seems founded upon their incredulity that a popular and competitive activity revolves around research, argumentation and knowledge, and in some

cases borders on reverence. Similarly, the students from Wiley College, and those represented in *Resolved* are enlightened students who employ debate as a liberator of potential. What *Debate Team*, *Thumbsucker*, and *Rocket Science* sometimes look down upon for its supposedly abnormal or antisocial tendencies, *The Great Debaters*, *Resolved*, and *Love and Debate* are willing to push further to create a mode of resistance to ignorance and privilege and general social apathy. Both sets of films reveal a culture that holds a love/hate relationship towards knowledge and refutation, a society that admires those willing to talk back, while also being quietly annoyed by them. This mixture of reverence and disdain is not absolute in any of the films, as it is not absolute in our society. As such the opportunity for those involved with the debate community is to try and live the former and not the latter.

Will Sears

Suengwon Chung

Wake Forest *University*

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